



The Power of Community - From The Desk of the Rebbe

I would like to confirm receipt of your letter — undated — in which you write about your emotional state etc. I believe that I have previously written a few times, that in my opinion — and this is what I have clearly seen in actuality — every person, without exception, has a natural need for social contact, though obviously, the level of dependency varies from person to person. When one tries to ignore this natural need it understandably brings to “complications” and the like. For those who for some reason have difficulty connecting with others, their only solution is as in the case of learning how to swim, which is impossible before entering the water, even when standing close to the edge of the river.

Rather, one must first jump into the water. Automatically, the process of gaining swimming skills begins, and eventually one masters them. Contemplating whilst standing at the edge of the river how, what, and in which manner he will learn to swim, is useless; as it is impossible to learn how to swim unless one is in water.

Pardon me for saying so, but this is the case in your regard. In your letter you argue whether or not to accept a job which will involve being in the presence and company of others, all whilst sitting in your own room or personal space.

Obviously, I do not intend to admonish, but rather try once more; possibly, this time my words will be effective and you will “jump in” to a situation in which you will be forced (at least for the first few days) to be amongst people outside of your own home, and I strongly hope that within a short amount of time it will no longer be a strain and you will see the great importance and gain, also for others in society, as it is not for naught that man was created with a natural need for social contact. How amazing are the words of our sages, which are a practical guide for day to day life, that any matter of holiness should be conducted in the presence of ten people, not only publicly but the complete form of public. There is also a known Chassidic saying repeated in the name of great Chassidic masters, that it is worse [to be] in Gan Eden all alone then to be in... with the company of other Jews.

With blessings for good news....

(Igros Kodesh, Vol. XVIII, p. 534)